

Word family: **pause / pauses / paused / pausing**

Base word: pause

Forms: pauses, paused, pausing

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Your sentence:

> “On stressful days, even spending a short time there feels like **pressing pause on the outside world**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **press pause on something** is figurative. It means **to temporarily suspend or step away from something so that you can have a short break from it**.

The image comes from pressing the **pause button** on a video, song, or recording.

繁體中文： **暫時按下暫停鍵；暫時抽離、停止面對某件事，讓自己休息一下**

中文翻譯：

> “...feels like **pressing pause on the outside world**.”

「.....感覺就像暫時替外面的世界**按下暫停鍵**。」

Here:

press pause on the outside world = 暫時把外界的忙碌、壓力和干擾擱置一旁

1. **pause = stop briefly before continuing (暫停) — 暫停；停頓一下**

This is the central meaning.

Meaning: To stop an activity briefly, usually with the expectation that it will continue afterwards.

Practice 1

> “She **paused** before answering.”

「她回答前**停頓了一下**。」

Practice 2

> “We **paused** for a few minutes to rest.”

「我們**暫停**了**幾分鐘**休息。」

Practice 3

> “He **paused** halfway through the explanation.”

「他解釋到一半時**停**了一下**。**」

pause = 短暫停止某個動作、活動或說話，之後通常會繼續

Common:

- * pause briefly
- * pause for a moment
- * pause before speaking
- * pause to think

2. **a pause** = short break/silence (停頓) — 暫停；停頓；短暫間歇

As a noun, **pause** means a short period during which something stops.

Practice 4

> “There was a long **pause** before she replied.”

「她回答之前有一段很長的**停頓**。」

Practice 5

> “After a short **pause**, the meeting continued.”

「短暫**停頓**後，會議繼續進行。」

a pause = 活動、聲音、說話等短暫停止的一段時間

This is the noun counterpart of Meaning 1.

3. **pause** = temporarily suspend media/device/process (媒體 / 科技) — 暫停播放；暫停運作

This is especially important because it supplies the metaphor in your passage.

Practice 6

> “Can you **pause** the video?”

「你可以把影片**暫停**嗎？」

Practice 7

> “I **paused** the podcast to answer the phone.”

「我把 Podcast **暫停播放**，去接電話。」

pause = 暫時停止影片、音樂、錄音、遊戲或某個數碼程序，但保留目前位置 / 狀態以便之後繼續

Common:

- * pause a video
- * pause playback
- * pause the game
- * pause recording

This is closely related to the basic temporary-stop meaning, but technologically conventional enough to show explicitly.

4. **pause** = pause button/function (名詞) — 暫停鍵；暫停功能

Pause can refer to the control or function that temporarily stops media.

Practice 8

> “Press **pause** if you need more time.”

「如果你需要更多時間，就按**暫停鍵**。」

Practice 9

> “I hit **pause** and went to make some tea.”

「我按了**暫停鍵**，然後去泡茶。」

pause = 播放器、電話、遊戲等上的暫停控制 / 功能

This is the literal source of your passage metaphor.

5. **press / hit pause on something = temporarily step away from it (比喻) — 暫時擱置；按下暫停鍵**

This is the exact construction used in your passage.

Practice 10 — Original

> “The library feels like **pressing pause on the outside world**.”

「圖書館讓我感覺像是替外面的世界**按下暫停鍵**。」

Practice 11

> “I need to **hit pause on** work for a few days.”

「我需要把工作**暫時放一放**幾天。」

Practice 12

> “They decided to **press pause on** the project.”

「他們決定**暫時擱置**這個項目。」

press/hit pause on something = 暫時停止或離開某項活動、壓力或計劃，之後可能再繼續

This is a metaphorical fixed construction rather than a separate core dictionary meaning.

6. **pause = hesitate briefly because of uncertainty/thought (猶豫 / 思考) — 猶豫；停下思考**

Sometimes **pause** emphasizes not merely stopping physically, but briefly hesitating to think.

Practice 13

> “The question made him **pause**.”

「這個問題令他**停下來想了一下**。」

Practice 14

> “She **paused**, unsure what to say next.”

「她**猶豫**了一下，不知道接下來該說甚麼。」

pause = 因思考、懷疑、意外或猶豫而短暫停下來

For strict counting, this remains under the basic temporary-stop meaning, but the pragmatic nuance is worth teaching.

7. **give someone pause** = make someone reconsider (固定表達) — 令某人重新思考；令某人有所顧慮

This is an important idiom.

Practice 15

> “The high cost gave me **pause**.”

「高昂的成本令我**有所顧慮 / 重新考慮**。」

Practice 16

> “The new evidence should give us **pause**.”

「這些新證據應該令我們**停下來重新想一想**。」

give someone pause = 令某人因顧慮、疑問或新資訊而停下來重新考慮

Do not interpret it literally as giving someone a break.

8. **pause for thought** = reason to stop and think (固定表達) — 值得深思；令人停下思考

Practice 17

> “The results should give us **pause for thought**.”

「這些結果值得我們**停下來深思**。」

This belongs to the reflective/hesitation extension.

9. **pause** = musical hold/rest-like marking (音樂) — 延長記號 ; 停頓

In music, **pause** can refer to a marked holding or suspension of a note/rest, especially in British terminology.

A **pause** may refer to the symbol also known as a **fermata**.

繁體中文 : **延長記號 ; 音樂中的停頓 / 延長**

This is a genuine specialist sense, but lower priority for general learners.

Important distinction: **pause** vs **stop**

pause

usually implies:

> temporary interruption, with continuation expected

stop

can mean:

> end completely or simply cease

Compare:

> “Pause the video.”

= 暫停 , 稍後繼續。

> “Stop the video.”

= 停止播放 ; 不一定會再繼續。

This distinction is central.

Important distinction: **pause** vs **break**

pause

= the act/state of briefly stopping

****break****

= a period deliberately taken away from an activity, often for rest

- > pause before answering
- > take a lunch break

A break is often longer and more intentional.

Important distinction: ****pause vs rest****

****rest****

focuses on recovering energy.

****pause****

focuses simply on temporarily stopping.

- > pause the discussion
- > rest after exercise

You can pause without resting.

Important distinction: ****pause vs hesitate****

****hesitate****

specifically means delay because you are unsure, nervous, or reluctant.

****pause****

is neutral; there may be many reasons for stopping.

- > pause to think
- > hesitate to answer

A hesitation is a type of pause, but not every pause is hesitation.

Important distinction: **pause** vs **suspend**

suspend

is more formal and often means officially or deliberately stop something temporarily.

pause

is more everyday.

> pause the project

> suspend operations

Suspend often sounds more institutional or formal.

Grammar note

Pause can be both:

Intransitive

> “She paused.”

「她停了一下。」

Transitive, especially media/processes

> “She paused the video.”

「她把影片暂停了。」

That transitive technological use is now very ordinary.

Countability note

As a noun, **pause** is countable:

> a pause

> several pauses

Examples:

- * a brief pause
- * an awkward pause
- * a long pause
- * a dramatic pause

In:

> press pause

****pause**** functions as the name of the control/function and normally appears without an article.

Useful collocations

- * brief pause
- * short pause
- * long pause
- * awkward pause
- * dramatic pause
- * pause briefly
- * pause for thought
- * pause to think
- * pause playback
- * press pause
- * hit pause

Family-extension note

The morphological family is small:

- * ****pause****
- * ****pauses****
- * ****paused****
- * ****pausing****

Most of its richness comes from grammatical constructions and metaphorical extensions rather than many derivational forms.

The core mental image remains highly stable:

> ****something temporarily stops but is capable of continuing****

That idea connects speech, activity, media playback, hesitation, and your figurative ****press pause**

on the outside world** construction.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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pause — verb, general	短暫停止動作、說話或活動，之後通常繼續
a pause — noun	某件事短暫停止的一段時間；停頓 / 間歇
pause — media/process	暫停影片、音樂、遊戲或程序，同時保留位置以便繼續
pause — button/function	暫停鍵 / 暫停功能
press/hit pause on something	暫時停止、擱置或抽離某件事
pause — hesitation/reflection	因思考、疑問或猶豫而短暫停下
give someone pause	令某人有所顧慮並重新考慮
pause — music	音樂中的停頓 / 延長記號；較專門

For your original sentence

> “On stressful days, even spending a short time there feels like **pressing pause on the outside world**.”

The exact meaning is:

press pause on = 暫時把某件事情停止或擱在一旁，讓自己短暫抽離

So:

> **pressing pause on the outside world**

= **暫時替外界的忙碌、壓力和干擾按下暫停鍵**

The outside world does not literally stop. The media-control image is being used metaphorically to express a temporary psychological break.

For your database, I would count **2 genuinely useful core meanings** for **pause**:

1. **temporarily stop / a temporary stop**
2. **temporarily suspend media, playback, or a controllable process**

I would treat hesitation/reflection as an extension of #1, and keep **press/hit pause on**, **give someone pause**, and **pause for thought** as important fixed constructions rather than artificially inflating the core count.